According to it, there was a great king named Nabhi who had a son, Rishabh. After ruling for a while, Rishabh would become an ascetic (in the Jain tradition, he is the founder, the first tirthankara) and handed over his throne to his son Bharat. As it turned out, Bharat would conquer the whole subcontinent and become a chakravartin. Thus, the country comes to be known as the Land of Bharat or Bharatavarsha. The link with the older Vedic story is unclear and one could speculate that Bharat's conquest is a distant memory of that of Sudas. Also unclear is the link to a later story about another all-conquering King Bharat, son of King Dushyant and Shakuntala.

Meanwhile, the ancient Avestan Persians would come to use the term Hapta Hindu, derived from Sapta Sindhu, through the phonetic shift of 's' to 'h'. The Avestans seem to have some dispute with the Vedic Indians as the Vendidad text mentions that Hapta Hindu had been taken over by evil gods (*devas*). Notice that the very first use of the word Hindu is mentioned as part of the name of a land and is not derived from the river Sindhu as commonly assumed.

The Middle East would continue to use 'Hindu' but the word would evolve to 'India' as it went further west. Thus, the name 'India' is the result of serial mispronunciation by ancient foreigners. In contrast, the word 'Bharat' would travel to Southeast Asia where it survives in Indonesian and Malaysian Bahasa as 'Barat', meaning west!

As one can see, this country has been indigenously called Bharat for thousands of years, and the name is commonly used in Indian languages. The use of India, however, is also very old. Many other countries have embraced external and internal names: Germany and Deutschland, Japan and Nippon. This is why the Indian Constitution begins with the words: "India, that is Bharat..." ■

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Illustration by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

The spectacular success of the G20 summit has done India proud. But the dinner hosted by the 'President of Bharat' and the use of Bharat (instead of India) on the invite has triggered a controversy on whether this was proper and whether the word India will soon have an expiry date.

On September 18, 1949, the Constituent Assembly debated on what the name of the new republic would be. The initial draft of Article 1 read: India shall be a Union of States. There was no reference to Bharat. H.V. Kamat and others suggested replacing India with Bharat, Bharatvarsha, Hind or Hindusthan. This proposal was put to vote and defeated. The amended and final version read: India, that is Bharat, shall be a Union of States. The lengthy debate led an exasperated Ambedkar to plead that as the word 'Bharat' was accepted, they should move on to bigger issues.

The word India occurs more than 550 times in the English version of the Constitution and, likewise, the word Bharat occurs more than 550 times in the Hindi version. 'Bharat' occurs only once in the English version, and the word 'इंडिया' occurs only once in the Hindi version. The Tamil and Malayalam versions use the word 'Bharatham'. Indeed, most of us use Bharat when speaking in the vernacular, except in some southern states. The sudden use of Bharat was thus surprising and baffling.

It would have been perfectly appropriate for the President to use '*Bharat ke Rashtrapati*' and send the cards in Hindi. The use of the hybrid version, 'Republic of Bharat', is constitutionally improper. Japan is the English name for 'Nihon' or 'Nippon'. Similarly, the German name